

Racers and Record-breakers

The speed of development in these early years was astonishing. At the start of the 20th century, only an airship could set a powered flight record, but in the first decade heavier-than-air craft went from their first staggering hops to flying 26 miles (42 km) across the English Channel at almost 50 mph (80 km/h). A decade later speeds had more than trebled and the first nonstop flight across the Atlantic had been achieved.

▷ Santos-Dumont No.6 1901

Origin France

Engine 20 hp Buchet water-cooled 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 23 mph (37 km/h)

Alberto Santos-Dumont won the 100,000 French franc "Deutsche" prize by flying from Parc Saint Cloud to the Eiffel Tower and back in under 30 minutes with this hydrogen-filled airship, on October 19, 1901.

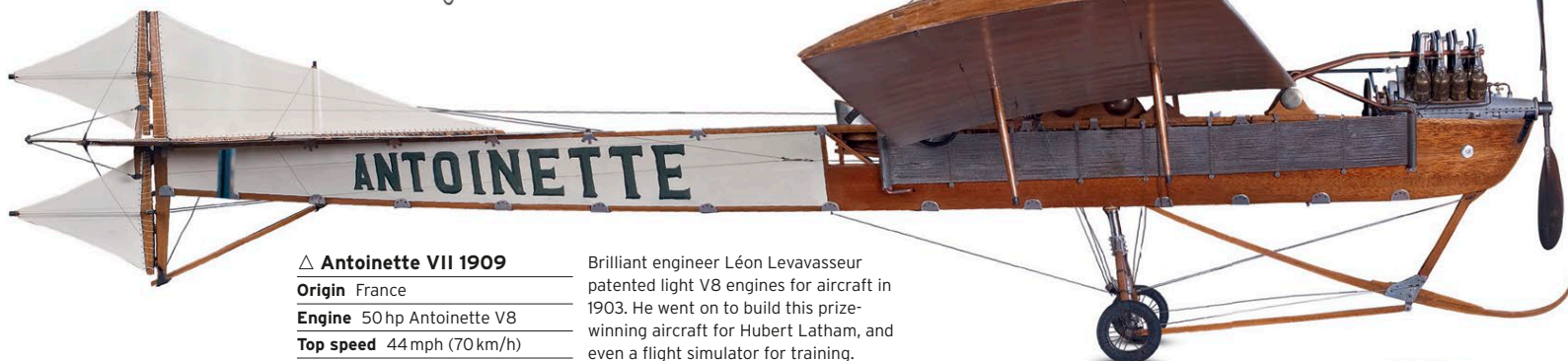
◁ Voisin-Farman Biplane No.1 1907

Origin France

Engine 50 hp Antoinette water-cooled V8

Top speed 56 mph (90 km/h)

Gabriel Voisin's first successful aircraft was flown by Henri Farman to achieve the inaugural 0.6 mile (1 km) closed-circuit flight, the earliest 1.2 mile (2 km), and then a 17-mile (27-km) flight across France in 20 minutes, all in 1908.



△ Antoinette VII 1909

Origin France

Engine 50 hp Antoinette V8

Top speed 44 mph (70 km/h)

Brilliant engineer Léon Levavasseur patented light V8 engines for aircraft in 1903. He went on to build this prize-winning aircraft for Hubert Latham, and even a flight simulator for training.

▷ Wright EX "Vin Fiz" 1911

Origin USA

Engine 35 hp Wright Aero 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 51 mph (82 km/h)

This was Calbraith Perry Rodgers's mount for the first coast-to-coast crossing of the US in 1911, with 75 stops including 16 crashes and numerous personal injuries. Many parts were replaced *en route*.



△ Morane-Saulnier H 1913

Origin France

Engine 80 hp Le Rhône 9C air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 75 mph (120 km/h)

This single-seat sporting aircraft won a precision landing contest in 1913 piloted by Roland Garros. The design was ordered by both France and England for combat use at the start of WWI.



▷ Astra Wright BB 1912

Origin USA/France

Engine 35 hp Barriquand et Marre 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 37 mph (60 km/h)

Dating from 1912 this French-built aircraft was based closely on the record-setting Wright Brothers Baby. The Baby flew from Springfield to St. Louis in 1910, a distance of 95 miles (153 km), and in 1911 crossed the US in only 83 hours' flying time.



△ Morane-Saulnier A1 Type XXX 1917

Origin France

Engine 150 hp Gnome Monosoupape 9N air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 140 mph (225 km/h)

This WWI single-seat fighter had aerobatic ability because of its compact dimensions and sweptback parasol wings. After war service it became a trainer, 51 going to the US Expeditionary Force.

